CHORDS BY EAR

Pacing guide · 5 days

PACING

Teacher

Five class periods of about 53 minutes: two learning days (ear first, then the keyboard and scales), two project days (chords, then Roman numerals) and a finishing and presenting day. Each day's full plan is on pages 7–9.

DAY	FOCUS AND GOAL	MINUTE BLOCKS	DECK
DAY 1 Learning	**Chords by ear: just listen** Every student has played the seven white-key chords and described each one in plain words, and heard the four-chord loop come home. No Roman numerals yet.	0–10 · Opening: one note, then chords 10–18 · Listen: a real song 18–45 · Play and describe 45–53 · Share-out	Intro deck slides 1–8
DAY 2 Learning	**The keyboard and scales** Every student can name all 7 white keys, tell a half step from a whole step, and build the C major and A natural minor scales.	0–5 · Bright or dark? 5–20 · The keyboard 20–30 · Logic: name every key 30–50 · Scales 50–53 · Exit question	Intro deck slides 9–10
DAY 3 Project day	**Build chords from formulas** Chord construction exercises complete. Students can build any major or minor chord from any root and enter it in the piano roll.	0–5 · What notes are those? 5–12 · The project 12–35 · Chord construction 35–50 · Logic: chords in the piano roll 50–53 · Save + check	Intro deck slides 11–15
DAY 4 Project day	**Roman numerals + Reference Card** Reference Card complete. Chords built over the bassline in Logic and labeled with their Roman numerals.	0–15 · Name what you already heard 15–40 · Packet, KCSRN + Reference Card 40–53 · Chords over the bassline	Intro deck slides 16–19
DAY 5 Finish + present	**Balance, finish, present** Every project submitted and presented; every student can point to their I chord and say why it feels like home.	0–8 · Mixing moment: balance 8–30 · Finish + submit 30–50 · Presentations 50–53 · Close	Intro deck slides 20–21

STUDENT PAGES BY DAY ·

Day 1	Day 1 post (p. 14), Chord Feel Log (p. 15)
Day 2	Day 2 post (p. 16), packet Parts 1–2 (pp. 18–19), reference sheet (p. 26)
Day 3	Project sheet (pp. 27–28), chords post (p. 17, step 1), packet Part 3 chords (p. 20)
Day 4	Chords post steps 2–5, Roman numerals (p. 21), KCSRN (p. 22), Reference Cards (pp. 23–25)
Day 5	Chord function table (p. 27), checklist (p. 30), rubric (p. 31)

PREVIEW

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CHORDS BY EAR

Chord Feel Log · play it, then describe it

STUDENT

Day 1 · by ear

Name _____ Date _____

Play each chord (all three notes at once) on a piano sound. Play it more than once. Then write what it feels like in your own words and circle bright or dark. No names needed today.

#	PLAY THESE NOTES	WHAT DOES IT FEEL LIKE? (YOUR WORDS)	CIRCLE ONE
1	C–E–G		bright · dark
2	F–A–C		bright · dark
3	G–B–D		bright · dark
4	A–C–E		bright · dark
5	D–F–A		bright · dark
6	E–G–B		bright · dark
7	B–D–F		bright · dark

LOOP 1 · PLAY IT ON REPEAT

C–E–G › F–A–C › G–B–D › C–E–G

What happens at the end? _____

Home is: _____

LOOP 2 · PLAY IT ON REPEAT

A–C–E › F–A–C › C–E–G › G–B–D

How is it different? _____

Home is: _____

Which chord felt most like home? _____

Which one wanted to go somewhere? _____

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C MAJOR — REFERENCE CARD

The Building Blocks · Unit 3 · Keep this open while you work

SCALE ·

C Major — W - W - H - W - W - W - H

C	D	E	F	G	A	B	C	(8)

CHORDS IN THIS KEY ·

RN	TYPE	CHORD	NOTES	FEELS LIKE…
I	Major	**C Major**	C - E - G	*Home. Settled. Complete.*
ii	Minor	**D Minor**	D - F - A	*Gentle tension. Moving somewhere.*
iii	Minor	**E Minor**	E - G - B	*Wistful. In between.*
IV	Major	**F Major**	F - A - C	*Lifting. Hopeful. Away from home.*
V	Major	**G Major**	G - B - D	*Homesick. Wants to resolve to I.*
vi	Minor	**A Minor**	A - C - E	*Tender. Melancholy. Emotional.*
vii°	Dim.	**B Dim.**	B - D - F	*Tense. Unstable. Rarely used alone.*

Remember: Roman numerals describe chord function, not just chord names.

The I chord always feels like home. · The V chord always feels unresolved. · The vi chord always feels tender or melancholy.

These feelings are the same in every key — only the note names change.

No sharps or flats in this key: every chord is white keys only. A minor uses the same seven notes: it is the relative minor.

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CHORDS BY EAR

Rubric

RUBRIC

/ 15

Name _____ Date _____

PART 3: CHORDS & ROMAN NUMERALS — RUBRIC

The Building Blocks · Unit 3 · /15

Each category is scored from 2 to 5.

Category	2	3	4	5	Score
CHORD CONSTRUCTION	Chords built with wrong notes or polyphonic errors. Formula not applied correctly.	Most chords correct but at least one has a construction error. Some formula misapplication.	All chords correctly constructed using R-4-3 or R-3-4. Notes stacked correctly in piano roll.	All chords correct, well-voiced, and labeled with Roman numerals. Demonstrates understanding of the formula.	
HARMONIC UNDERSTANDING	Chord function table incomplete or descriptions show no understanding of how chords feel.	Table complete but descriptions are vague or generic (e.g. 'sounds good').	Table complete. Student can describe what each chord feels like in their own words.	Table complete with specific, accurate descriptions. Student clearly understands why each chord was chosen.	
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	Not submitted or not presented.	Submitted late or named incorrectly. Minimal presentation engagement.	Correctly named and submitted. Presentation made. Reference Card completed.	Correctly named, on time. Student explains chord choices using Roman numeral language.	
				TOTAL	**/ 15**

MY I CHORD FEELS LIKE HOME BECAUSE...

_____

_____

_____

TEACHER COMMENTS

_____

_____

_____

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